

UNDERCOVER

The cable experience

Agent 001 files his report on the cable Internet scene. Read on to see whether a cable Internet connection is the answer to your surfing woes



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

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Bandwidth of up to 256 Kbps! Download speed of up to 24 Kbytes per second! My eyes goggled and my mind boggled. Adrenaline pumped through my entire system. Everything that was being said about cable Internet seemed to be too good! Too good to be true, in fact. So I decided to find out for myself if this latest boon for Internet junkies was in fact everything that it was cracked up to be.

My first stop was in the vicinity of Santa Cruz and Bandra in Mumbai, where I spoke to two cable operators, who are now providing Internet access. What they had to say about the benefits of cable Internet was nothing that I hadn't already heard—"This connection is not through the phone...this is the fastest form of Internet access that you can get for your home...you won't have to pay any phone bills to surf the Net...you can get online whenever you want to, for however long you want..."

I was definitely intrigued, so I decided to take a closer look at how these operators actually go about setting up your cable Internet connection. What I learnt was that in reality, none of these operators actually offered 'cable Internet access' in the true sense of the phrase. Cable Internet access usually requires a cable modem for each individual connection. But what I found was that cable operators usually provide the Internet connection through a WAN, which connects a large number of buildings and residences through a central server. A conventional LAN

card is installed on your computer and you are then linked to the operator's central server using either the standard UTP (Unshielded Twisted Pair) or coaxial cable. This method of connectivity is similar to the manner in which homes are connected with cable TV and—as I realized while overseeing one of the installations—just as unstructured! A wire is simply strung from one house to another via a hub. In a housing society, this would imply wires running all over the place, over windowpanes, over pipes and along them, and it gets even messier as the number of subscribers increases.

I also found that the only factor that differed from one operator to the other was the cost of installation and the monthly charges. In places where cable Internet services were already available for a couple of months, the monthly rentals were approximately Rs 100 to Rs 300 cheaper than in places where cable services had just been set up. Installation charges ranged between Rs 4,000 to Rs 6,000 and all operators I spoke with offered a 100 Mbps LAN card as part of the installation. I found that operators preferred UTP cables over coaxial cables because they were easy to install. "Troubleshooting connections with UTP cables is much easier compared to coaxial cables—less *janjhat*!"

What about the special services offered with cable Internet, you ask? Well, if the operator has a private ISP license and his own Web server, then you could get an e-mail account. You could also get telephony services, allowing you to make long-distance calls over the Internet at much cheaper rates. While most operators said they were in the process of procuring a private ISP license and having their own Web server running, they seemed hesitant about providing telephony services as Internet-based telephony services are not yet legal in India.

Well, all said and done, cable Internet does provide faster access and download speeds, but only when a few people are online. In a cabled network neighborhood, a large number of households share a single transmission cable and the bandwidth gets split among all of them. So performance tends to take a big dip at peak hour. 

Smart Buyer Tips

Keep these points in mind while going in for a cable Internet connection

- Preferably go in for the Internet connection in a group. Cable operators give discounts when more than one person goes in for the connection as part of a group. It's also easier to implement if your neighbour has a connection.
- If you buy the LAN card yourself rather than having the operator install it, you can save a couple of hundred rupees.

- Go in for the 'unlimited package' where there is no time restriction on how long you can surf, as opposed to a time-restricted scheme. Some operators do offer this, so make sure you go in for the right package.

- Get in touch with the technical personnel and find out the actual minimum that your speed could drop to. See that this is not lower than 64 Kbps, otherwise there would effectively be little difference compared to your older modem-based Internet experience.

Want to share your experiences with getting a cable Internet connection installed?
Write in to readersletters@jasubhai.com